MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 2: Sir Roger at Home and The Battle of the Books

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Addison examines a household through affectionate observation, while Swift makes a literary quarrel into a mock battle over knowledge, authority, and vanity.

Start with a picture

A visitor describes a host’s kindness and eccentric habits. In another story, books leap from their shelves and fight. Neither account is innocent description: each guides the reader’s judgement through a chosen perspective.

1. Addison: Sir Roger at Home

The visiting narrator observes Sir Roger’s household, treatment of servants, hospitality, routines, and social relationships. The portrait gives a country gentleman warmth and individuality without making him a perfect model.

Small details create a sense of continuity. A servant’s long association, a familiar habit, or an interaction can imply how authority is exercised within daily life.

2. Affectionate irony and paternalism

The narrator can value Sir Roger while noticing an oddity or limitation. **Irony** need not be cruel. A qualified admiration can be more revealing than either complete praise or ridicule.

The household also depends on hierarchy. **Paternalism** describes authority justified through a father-like claim of protection and care. Kindness within that arrangement does not automatically give dependants equal power. Analyse both the warmth and the institution.

3. Swift: The Battle of the Books

The essay’s wider controversy concerns the prestige of ancient and modern learning. Swift transforms the quarrel into combat among books in a library, using the style of heroic warfare for an intellectual dispute.

Sir William Temple, William Wotton, and Richard Bentley belong to the historical debate. Their arguments and Swift’s satirical versions of them should not be treated as identical.

4. The spider and the bee

The spider boasts of producing from within itself; the bee gathers from the world and transforms what it collects. The contrast supports an argument about inherited knowledge, productive use, and claims to self-sufficiency.

It is an allegory, not a scientific account of which insect is morally better. Explain how the comparison makes a position appear admirable or ridiculous.

5. Mock-heroic method

Personification makes books into combatants; elevated comparisons enlarge the dispute; tonal shifts expose self-importance. The manuscript-like presentation and its breaks complicate a simple report of final victory.

Swift’s satire does not amount to a rejection of every new discovery. It targets pretension and the terms in which intellectual authority is claimed.

6. Compare the methods

Addison’s measured observation and Swift’s extravagant conflict are different prose resources. Both reveal that a narrator’s manner directs an audience’s judgement. Ask what each voice invites us to notice and what assumptions support it.

Quick check

1. Does a kindly household mean an equal household? **Not necessarily.**
2. Is Swift narrating an actual fight between printed books? **No; personification and allegory organise satire.**
3. Does the bee simply copy without transforming? **No; gathering and transformation are central.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain the narrator’s place in Addison.
2. Analyse a household detail and affectionate irony.
3. Qualify paternal benevolence.
4. Discuss Swift’s historical quarrel and insect allegory.
5. Compare how form directs judgement.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not equate care with equality or take Swift’s satirical portrayal of an opponent as an objective summary of all modern learning.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare how perspective and figurative method shape judgement in Addison and Swift.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Sir Roger at Home creates its effect through a visitor’s attentive and qualified admiration. Household details make the host seem particular rather than an abstract moral example. The narrator’s restraint permits affection and criticism to coexist, so an eccentricity can qualify a portrait without destroying its warmth.

That warmth should not make the social arrangement invisible. The household’s care and continuity operate within a hierarchy. A critical reading can recognise benevolence while asking how dependants’ perspectives are represented. Perspective is therefore both a source of intimacy and a limit on knowledge.

The Battle of the Books makes its intervention through a far more extravagant displacement. Literary controversy becomes heroic combat, and the spider-and-bee allegory gives competing accounts of intellectual production a memorable shape. Personification and inflated style expose vanity while inviting the reader towards a particular judgement about learning.

An effective comparison explains these formal differences instead of identifying one essay as realistic and the other merely fanciful. Both arrange evidence through a speaking position. Their methods teach readers to value certain habits and claims, and those invitations can themselves be examined.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Analyse Addison’s use of detailed description and satirical aloofness to bring Sir Roger de Coverley to life as a realistic character.
2. Design a character analysis chart showing how Sir Roger’s treatment of his servants, chaplain, and guests reveals his personality traits and social values.
3. Discuss Addison’s writing style and his use of humour in the essay “Sir Roger at Home.”
4. Explore Addison’s realistic portrayal of characters in the essay “Sir Roger at Home.”
5. Write a note on Addison’s description of country state and its people in the essay “Sir Roger at Home.

6. Analyse the spider-and-bee allegory, discussing its symbolic function and its effectiveness in representing the ancients and the moderns.
7. Write an essay essay on mock-heroic techniques in “The Battle of the Books”.
8. Investigate the historical controversy between Temple, Wotton, and Bentley and assess Swift’s accuracy in his satirical portrayal.
9. Create profiles of five key “combatant” books, explaining how each embodies specific intellectual or moral flaws criticised by Swift.
10. Propose a modern “battle of the books” by selecting ten contemporary texts to represent two opposing intellectual camps.